UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Literary Criticism

State • 2017



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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • State • 2017

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. A figurative phrase used in Old Germanic languages as a synonym for a simple noun is known as (a)

   A) caesura.
   B) euphemism.
   C) kenning.
   D) metonymy.
   E) syllepsis.

2. The prose fiction genre that places unusual emphasis on interior characterization and on the motives, circumstances, and internal action that spring from and develop external action is the

   A) campus novel.
   B) epistolary novel.
   C) picaresque novel.
   D) psychological novel.
   E) sociological novel.

3. The group of American writers of the 1950s and the 1960s in rebellion against what they conceived of as the failures of American culture is the

   A) Agrarians.
   B) Angry Young Men.
   C) Beat Generation.
   D) Lollards.
   E) Muckrakers.

4. The playwright who wrote *Fences* and *The Piano Lesson*, both of which earned him Pulitzer Prizes for Drama, in 1987 and 1990, respectively, is

   A) Neil Simon.
   B) Alfred Uhry.
   C) Thornton Wilder.
   D) Tennessee Williams.
   E) August Wilson.

5. An eighteenth-century philosophical movement, particularly in France, that gave shape to the American Revolution and the two foundational documents of the United States, the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution, is the

   A) Commonwealth or Puritan Interregnum.
   B) Enlightenment.
   C) Great Awakening.
   D) Renaissance.
   E) Romantic Movement.

6. **Not** one of the characters in Greek drama, one coined by Northrup Frye, is the

   A) agroikos.
   B) alazon.
   C) eiron.
   D) gerontion.
   E) protagonist.

7. The name given to the eleventh- through thirteenth-century lyric poets and composers of Provence who focused on stories of love and chivalry is

   A) bard.
   B) *jongleur*.
   C) minstrel.
   D) scop.
   E) troubadour.

8. A poem in which the lines are so arranged that they form a design on the page, taking the shape of the subject is called, among other terms, (a/n)

   A) altar poem.
   B) clerihew.
   C) echo verse.
   D) rebus.
   E) square poem.

9. The eighteenth-century British author of three epistolary novels, the most well-known being *Pamela: Or, Virtue Rewarded*, is

   A) Daniel Defoe.
   B) Henry Fielding.
   C) Samuel Johnson.
   D) Samuel Richardson.
   E) Jonathan Swift.

10. The group of late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century writers in France, England, and the United States who held that art is superior to nature and that the finest beauty is that of dying or decaying things is known as the

    A) Aesthetes.
    B) Decadents.
    C) Lost Generation.
    D) Parnassians.
    E) Pre-Raphaelites.

11. A type of repetition in which a word or phrase coming last or in another important place in one sentence or line of poetry is repeated at the beginning of the next is called

A) anadiplosis.
B) analecta.
C) anaphora.
D) anastomosis.
E) asyndeton.

12. The form of verse to be sung or recited and characterized by its presentation of a dramatic or exciting episode in simple narrative form is the

A) antiphon.
B) ballad.
C) madrigal.
D) rondeau.
E) round.

13. The author of "Richard Cory" and recipient of the 1922, 1925, and 1928 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry is

A) Stephen Vincent Benét.
B) John Gould Fletcher.
C) Edwin Arlington Robinson.
D) William Carlos Williams.
E) Franz Wright.

14. The art and practice of writing metrical compositions, including the transformation of prose into a metrical composition, is known as

A) exegesis.
B) reception theory.
C) scansion.
D) typology.
E) versification.

15. Stories that relate the mysterious pranks and adventures of spirits manifesting themselves in the form of diminutive human beings who possess supernatural wisdom and foresight, a mischievous temperament, the power to regulate the affairs of human beings, and the capacity to change their shapes belong to a genre that became poplar toward the end of the seventeenth century; the genre is

A) fairy tale.
B) legend.
C) masque.
D) parable.
E) tall tale.

16. Text, such as IOU and PED XING, in which ordinary verbal symbols are supplemented by pictures and other devices to suggest total meaning is called a(n)

A) acrostic.
B) *carmen figuratum.*
C) figure poem.
D) rebus.
E) shaped verse.

17. One person's particular language—including vocabulary, syntax, pronunciation—slightly different from everybody else's is called (a/n)

A) colloquialism.
B) dialect.
C) idiolect.
D) idiom.
E) jargon.

18. **Not** one of nineteenth-century American author Mark Twain's many novels is

A) *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn.*
B) *The Adventures of Tom Sawyer.*
C) *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court.*
D) *Roughing It.*
E) *The Scarlet Letter*.

19. The term coined by E. M. Forster for a character sufficiently complex to be able to surprise the reader without losing credibility is

A) dynamic character.
B) flat character.
C) round character.
D) static character.
E) stock character.

20. The verse form—a favorite of Chaucer that did not come into its greatest popularity until the middle of the seventeenth century when it became the dominant mode for poetic drama, especially under the creative genius of John Dryden, and later as a fixed form in poetic expression with Alexander Pope—that is comprised of iambic pentameter lines rhymed in pairs is known as (the)

A) blank verse.
B) heroic couplet.
C) hymnal stanza.
D) projection verse.
E) sapphic stanza.

21. The recently-deceased twentieth-century British playwright, author of *The Dumb Waiter*, *The Homecoming*, and the absurdist play *The Birthday Party*, and screenwriter for Franz Kafka's *The Trial*, who received the 2005 Nobel Prize for Literature is

A) T. S. Eliot.
B) William Golding.
C) V. S. Naipaul.
D) Harold Pinter.
E) George Bernard Shaw.

22. The Japanese verse form characterized by seventeen syllables arranged in lines of five, seven, and five syllables and relying on humor or satire is the

A) haiku.
B) kabuki.
C) manga.
D) senryu.
E) tanka.

23. The gathering of writers and thinkers, many of whom lived in a residential district near central London after which the group takes its name, counting among its membership Virginia Woolf, Lytton Strachey, E. M. Forster, and John Maynard Keynes, among others, is the

A) Bloomsbury Group.
B) Bluestockings.
C) Fugitives.
D) Knickerbocker Group
E) Scriblerus Club.

24. The nineteenth-century author of *Uncle Tom's Cabin* and supporter of the Underground Railroad is

A) Louisa May Alcott.
B) Kate Chopin.
C) Margaret Fuller.
D) Harriet Beecher Stowe.
E) Phillis Wheatley.

25. The term that embodies the application of principles of scientific determinism in literature, which, in turn, characterizes a literary movement of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, is

A) Darwinism.
B) meliorism.
C) naturalism.
D) objectivism.
E) surrealism.

26. The twentieth-century African-American author of the highly acclaimed sociological novel *Invisible Man*, a powerful study of the alienating effect of racism, and the posthumously published novel *Three Days before the Shooting* (2010) is

A) James Baldwin.
B) Ralph Ellison.
C) Langston Hughes.
D) James Weldon Johnson.
E) Richard Wright.

27. **Not** among the terms applied to the movement to preserve and reconstruct early Celtic history and literature is

A) Celtic Renaissance.
B) Celtic Revival.
C) Gaelic Movement.
D) Irish Literary Movement.
E) The Movement.

28. The genre of drama developed in late fifteenth and early sixteenth-century England that played an important part in the secularization of drama and in the evolution of realistic comedy and is characterized by brevity, wit, homely details, and realistic treatment of life is the

A) burlesque.
B) interlude.
C) miracle play.
D) morality play.
E) mystery play.

29. The recipient of the 1988 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for her novel *Beloved* is

A) Toni Morrison.
B) Nelly Sachs.
C) Carol Shields.
D) Elizabeth Strout.
E) Anne Tyler.

30. The literary movement of the second half of the nineteenth century broadly defined by fidelity to actuality in representation and more precisely centered in the novel is called

A) magic realism.
B) modernism.
C) orphism.
D) philistinism.
E) realism.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with William Shakespeare's *Twelfth Night, or, What You Will*.
Items 37-42 are associated with Amy Tan's *The Joy Luck Club*.
Items 43-50 are associated with Rudyard Kipling's poetry (selected).

31. In Shakespeare's *Twelfth Night* the momentary upstaging of the tenor by the vehicle in the Captain's allusion to a Greek legend in which "like Arion on the dolphin's back," Sebastian rode the waves on a floating mast constitutes a(n)

A) controlling image.
B) dead metaphor.
C) diminishing metaphor.
D) epic simile.
E) Homeric epithet.

32. The tone reflected in Toby's response to Maria upon hearing her plan regarding Malvolio, "Good night, Penthesilea," is one of

A) awed regard.
B) cowed regard.
C) flippant disdain.
D) flippant flattery.
E) hagiographic disdain.

33. Orsino's accusatory address, delivered after a naval battle is recounted, "Notable pirate, thou saltwater thief," is directed at

A) Antonio.
B) Fabian.
C) Feste.
D) Sebastian.
E) Valentine.

34. Viola's retort to the Fool's commentary on having a good wit, "They that dally nicely with words may quickly make them wanton," finds precision in the word *nicely*, which means

A) cautiously.
B) genially.
C) genteelly.
D) politely.
E) precisely.

35. The Fool's comment "thou art more puzzled than the Egyptians in their fog" constitutes a

A) metaphor based in a historical allusion.
B) paradox combined with xenoglossia.
C) pun characterized by "mysticism."
D) quibble about luminous vapors.
E) simile based in a biblical allusion.

36. Maria's active setting up of Malvolio begins with her saying, "Lie thou there, for here comes the trout that must be caught with tickling." The "trout" is Malvolio, and the bait to which Maria has delivered the command "Lie thou there" is the

A) bear.
B) cankerworm inside a rosebud.
C) dueling sword.
D) forged letter.
E) Lucrece knife.

37. In Tan's *Joy Luck Club*, the matchmaker's observation that she, "loaded [. . .] down with gold bracelets," is "too balanced to have babies" refers to

A) Lindo Jong.
B) Waverly Jong.
C) Lena St. Clair.
D) Ying-Ying St. Clair.
E) Huang Taitai.

38. The source of Jing-mei's "wondering how disappointed [her] mother must have been" in her stems from a discussion with her father about

A) her Americanisms.
B) her failed expectations.
C) her losses at the mahjong table.
D) her name.
E) her sisters.

39. The recollection, "So I didn't have instant love for my future husband the way you see on television today," points to the cultural and generational differences in the specifics of the life of

A) An-mei Hsu.
B) Lindo Jong.
C) Rose Hsu Jordan.
D) Jing-mei Woo.
E) Suyan Woo.

40. Uncle Tin's practiced joke, "I tell my daughter, Hey why be poor? Marry rich!" turns on a

A) hyperbole.
B) paradox.
C) pun.
D) *rime riche*.
E) solecism.

41. Lena St. Clair's reflection on her self-imposed penance, "wondering why it was that eating something good could make me feel so terrible, while vomiting something terrible could make me feel so good," is a(n)

A) conceit developed of metonymy.
B) Irish proverb.
C) mistranslation of a Chinese aphorism.
D) paradox built on chiasmus.
E) understatement couched in gustatory imagery.

42. Marlene's advice is met with "Well, I don't know if it's explicitly stated in the law, but you can't ever tell a Chinese mother to shut up. You could be charged as an accessory to your own murder," which serves as a defining of the relationship between

A) Rose and An-mei Hsu.
B) Waverly and Lindo Jong.
C) Wang Chwun Yu and Wang Chwun Hwa Chwun.
D) Jing-mei and Suyuan Woo.
E) Lena and Ying-ying St. Clair.

Items 43-45 refer to Rudyard Kipling's

Justice
October 1918

Across a world where all men grieve
And grieving strive the more,
The great days range like tides and leave
Our dead on every shore.
Heavy the load we undergo,
And our own hands prepare,
If we have parley with the foe,
The load our sons must bear.

Before we loose the word
That bids new worlds to birth,
Needs must we loosen first the sword
Of Justice upon earth;
Or else all else is vain
Since life on earth began,
And the spent world sinks back again
Hopeless of God and Man.

A People and their King
Through ancient sin grown strong,
Because they feared no reckoning
Would set no bound to wrong;
But now their hour is past,
And we who bore it find
Evil Incarnate held at last
To answer to mankind.

For agony and spoil
Of nations beat to dust,
For poisoned air and tortured soil
And cold, commanded lust,
And every secret woe
The shuddering waters saw—
Willed and fulfilled by high and low—
Let them relearn the Law:

That when the dooms are read,
Not high nor low shall say:—
'My haughty or my humble head
Has saved me in this day.'
That, till the end of time,
Their remnant shall recall
Their fathers' old, confederate crime
Availed them not at all:

That neither schools nor priests,
Nor Kings may build again
A people with the heart of beasts
Made wise concerning men.
Whereby our dead shall sleep
In honour, unbetrayed,
And we in faith and honour keep
That peace for which they paid.

43. The second stanza of Kipling's "Justice" speaks of "the word / That bids new worlds to birth," which is a reference to (the)

A) auctioning of newly won territories.
B) command to go to war.
C) evolution of planets.
D) relationship between *word* and *sword*.
E) signing of a treaty.

44. Line 27's "poisoned air" and "tortured soil" and line 30's "shuddering water" recall WWI's

A) dauntless bravery.
B) ecoterrorism.
C) new weaponry.
D) trench warfare.
E) wholesale desertion.

45. Line 17, "A People and their King," is a reference to

A) England and Edward VII.
B) England and George V.
C) France and Louis IV.
D) Germany and Wilhelm II.
E) Italy and Victor Emmanuel III.

Items 46-50 refer to Rudyard Kipling's

The White Man's Burden

Take up the White Man's burden—
  Send forth the best ye breed—
Go bind your sons to exile
  To serve your captives' need;
To wait in heavy harness
  On fluttered folk and wild—
Your new-caught sullen peoples,
  Half devil and half child.

Take up the White Man's burden—
  In patience to abide
To veil the threat of terror
  And check the show of pride;
By open speech and simple,
  An hundred times made plain,
To seek another's profit,
  And work another's gain.

Take up the White Man's burden—
  The savage wars of peace—
Fill full the mouth of famine
  And bid the sickness cease;
And when your goal is nearest
  The end for others sought,
Watch Sloth and heathen Folly
  Bring all your hopes to nought.

Take up the White Man's burden—
  No tawdry rule of kings,
But toil of serf and sweeper—
  The tale of common things.
The ports ye shall not enter,
  The roads ye shall not tread,
Go make them with your living,
  And mark them with your dead!

Take up the White Man's burden—
  And reap his old reward,
The blame of those ye better,
  The hate of those ye guard—
The cry of hosts ye humour
  (Ah slowly!) towards the light:—
'Why brought ye us from bondage,
  Our loved Egyptian night?'

Take up the White Man's burden—
  Ye dare not stoop to less—
Nor call too loud on Freedom
  To cloak your weariness;
By all ye cry or whisper,
  By all ye leave or do,
The silent sullen peoples
  Shall weigh your Gods and you.

Take up the White Man's burden—
  Have done with childish days—
The lightly proffered laurel,
  The easy, ungrudged praise.
Comes now, to search your manhood
  Through all the thankless years,
Cold-edged with dear-bought wisdom,
  The judgment of your peers.

46. The lines of Kipling's "The White Man's Burden" that work to sum up the argued altruism that underlies the poem's crusading are

A) lines 5-6.
B) lines 11-12.
C) lines 15-16.
D) lines 27-28.
E) lines 34-36.

47. Line 18's "savage wars of peace" constitutes (a/n)

A) antithesis.
B) equivoque.
C) hyperbole.
D) paradox.
E) tautology.

48. Inescapably, the thrust of Kipling's "The White Man's Burden" necessitates the pairing of imperialism and

A) death.
B) freedom.
C) manhood.
D) racism.
E) war.

49. Kipling's intended audience is/are the

A) American government.
B) British government.
C) British military.
D) Filipino people.
E) white missionaries in the Philippines.

50. The rhetorical question "Why brought ye us from bondage, / Our loved Egyptian night?" (lines 39-40) is carried by a

A) biblical allusion.
B) classical allusion.
C) historical allusion.
D) literary allusion.
E) topical allusion.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-54 refer to Edna St. Vincent Millay's

What lips my lips have kissed, and where, and why

What lips my lips have kissed, and where, and why,
I have forgotten, and what arms have lain
Under my head till morning; but the rain
Is full of ghosts tonight, that tap and sigh
Upon the glass and listen for reply,
And in my heart there stirs a quiet pain
For unremembered lads that not again
Will turn to me at midnight with a cry.
Thus in the winter stands the lonely tree,
Nor knows what birds have vanished one by one,
Yet knows its boughs more silent than before:
I cannot say what loves have come and gone,
I only know that summer sang in me
A little while, that in me sings no more

51. Millay's closed-form poem is an example of a(n)
A) Anglo-Norman sonnet.
B) Italian sonnet.
C) Miltonic sonnet.
D) Shakespearian sonnet.
E) Spenserian sonnet.

52. Millay's use of more conjunctions than is normal, as found in the first line of the sonnet, is called
A) asyndeton.
B) epanalepsis.
C) pleonasm.
D) polyptoton.
E) polysyndeton.

53. The formula that pervades Millay's poem, both its theme and tone is
A) *carpe diem.*
B) *la femme inspiratice.*
C) *in medias res.*
D) *ubi sunt*.
E) *verbum infans.*

54. The sonnet's volta occurs at the beginning of
A) line 9.
B) line 10.
C) line 11.
D) line 12.
E) line 13.

Items 55-58 refer to Wilfred Owen's

Futility

Move him into the sun—
Gently its touch awoke him once,
At home, whispering of fields unsown.
Always it woke him, even in France,
Until this morning and this snow.
If anything might rouse him now
The kind old sun will know.

Think how it wakes the seeds,—
Woke, once, the clays of a cold star.
Are limbs, so dear-achieved, are sides,
Full-nerved,—still warm,—too hard to stir?
Was it for this the clay grew tall?
— O what made fatuous sunbeams toil
To break earth's sleep at all?

55. The kind of rhyme that Owen uses extensively and to good purpose in "Futility" in order to sample the dissonance of war, including its effects, is
A) assonance.
B) consonance.
C) feminine rhyme.
D) internal rhyme.
E) triple rhyme.

56. The speaker's internal audience can be correctly assumed to be
A) coroners.
B) fellow soldiers.
C) first responders.
D) triage surgeons.
E) undertakers.

57. In the final line of "Futility," Owen's metaphorical "earth's sleep" refers to a lack of
A) clay.
B) fatuous sunbeams.
C) life.
D) peace.
E) war.

58. Overall, the tone of Owen's poem is
A) capricious.
B) elegiac.
C) histrionic.
D) nonchalant.
E) supercilious.

Items 59-62 refer to Robert Francis's

Swimmer

I

Observe how he negotiates his way
With trust and the least violence, making
The stranger friend, the enemy ally.
The depth that could destroy him gently supports him.
With water he defends himself from water.
Danger he leans on, rests in. The drowning sea
Is all he has between himself and drowning.

II

What lover ever lay more mutually
With his beloved, his always-reaching arms
Stroking in smooth and powerful caresses?
Some drown in love as dark water, and some
By love are strongly held as the green sea
Now holds the swimmer. Indolently he turns
To float—the swimmer floats, the lover sleeps.

59. Central to Francis's "Swimmer" is the idea introduced by line 1's "negotiates," which sets up a theme of

A) caresses and violence.
B) competition and struggle.
C) compromise and balance.
D) drowning in life and love.
E) swimming in the green sea of love.

60. Line 3's adherence to the iambic necessitates two instances of

A) catalexis.
B) ellipsis.
C) parataxis.
D) pleonasm.
E) syllepsis.

61. The full effect of "The drowning sea / Is all he has between himself and drowning" (6-7) depends on (a/n)

A) ambiguity.
B) hyperbole.
C) litotes.
D) paradox.
E) zeugma.

62. Lines 13-14 offer a dramatic shift from mutuality to

A) apathetic termination.
B) careless inactivity.
C) comfortable autonomy.
D) defiant adversity.
E) exuberant achievement.

Items 63-65 refer to Anne Sexton's

Lobster

A shoe with legs,
a stone dropped from heaven,
he does his mournful work alone,
he is like the old prospector for gold,
with secret dreams of God-heads and fish heads.
Until suddenly a cradle fastens round him
and his is trapped as the U.S.A. sleeps.
Somewhere far off a woman lights a cigarette;
somewhere far off a car goes over a bridge;
somewhere far off a bank is held up.
This is the world the lobster knows not of.
He is the old hunting dog of the sea
who in the morning will rise from it
and be undrowned
and they will take his perfect green body
and paint it red.

63. The imagery of Anne Sexton's "Lobster" finds its best expression in a series of

A) connotations.
B) hyperboles.
C) metaphors.
D) paradoxes.
E) similes.

64. Line 5's metaphysical and physical objects of the preposition ***of*** are yoked in a fine example of

A) hypallage.
B) metonymy.
C) reification.
D) synæsthesia.
E) zeugma.

65. Many of the lines of Sexton's "Lobster" are characterized by

A) anaphora.
B) epanalepsis.
C) merism.
D) polyptoton.
E) symploce.

Required tie-breaking essay prompt on the next page.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Maya Angelou's "My Arkansas," and offer a discussion of imagery's contribution, through the comparisons central to each stanza, to the poem's subject.

My Arkansas

There is a deep brooding
in Arkansas.
Old crimes like moss pend*
from poplar trees.
The sullen earth
is too much too
red for comfort.

Sunrise seems to hesitate
and in that second
lose its
incandescent aim, and
dusk no more shadows
than the noon.
The past is brighter yet.

Old hates and
ante-bellum* lace, are rent*
but not discarded.
Today is yet to come
in Arkansas.
It writhes. It writhes in awful
waves of brooding.

1978

*** hang**
*** before the [Civil] War**
*** torn; ripped**

KEY

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line arrows up ➔

1.	C	266
2.	D	388
3.	C	51
4.	E	608
5.	B	174
6.	A	11
7.	E	487
8.	A	16
9.	D	546
10.	B	132
11.	A	21
12.	B	49
13.	C	604
14.	E	496
15.	A	192
16.	D	401
17.	C	245
18.	E	561
19.	C	425
20.	B	230
21.	D	601
22.	D	438
23.	A	61
24.	D	561
25.	C	315
26.	B	360
27.	E	79
28.	B	255
29.	A	603
30.	E	398
31.	D	1.2.16
32.	A	2.3.175
33.	A	5.1.65
34.	E	3.1.14
35.	E	4.2.46
36.	D	2.5.19
37.	A	63
38.	D	281
39.	B	52
40.	C	203
41.	D	154
42.	B	173
43.	E	
44.	C	
45.	D	
46.	C	
47.	D	349
48.	D	
49.	A	
50.	A	
51.	B	260
52.	E	373
53.	D	489
54.	A	
55.	B	107
56.	B	
57.	C	
58.	B	166
59.	C	
60.	B	168
61.	D	349
62.	C	
63.	C	294
64.	E	509
65.	A	24

FOLD along the **three** longitudinal lines for ease in grading. ➔

Please note that the objective scores should not be altered to reflect the breaking of any ties. ***Simply adjust ranking***.

The thirty items in Part 1 are worth one point each.

The twenty items in Part 2 are worth two points each.

The fifteen items in Part 3 are worth two points each.

DO NOT mark (cross out) actual **LETTER** answer; mark the answer **NUMERAL**.

Page numbers refer to the *Handbook* 12e, the Folger Shakespeare *Twelfth Night*, the Penguin *The Joy Luck Club*, and to Washington's Kipling collection.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Maya Angelou's "My Arkansas"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of imagery's contribution—with a focus on the three central comparisons—to the subject of Maya Angelou's "My Arkansas" include

alliteration,
allusion,
chiaroscuro,
connotation,
consonance,
diction,
epanalepsis,
free verse,
imagery,
liminality,
metalepsis (transumption),
metaphor,
metonymy,
paradox,
personification,
pun,
resonance,
setting,
sigmatism,
simile,
speaker,
symbolism,
synæsthesia,
theme,
tone, and
zeugma.

The young Literary Criticism contestant should recognize that the poem's imagery finds its strongest expression in the poem's two similes, "old crimes like moss pend / from popular trees" (lines 3-4) and "dusk no more shadows / than the moon" (lines 12-13). The dark symbolism resonating (Billie Holiday's "strange fruit") through the visual imagery of pending moss—the lynching associated with both the ante-bellum South and the Jim Crow era—into the second stanza's seeming personification of the natural order, which reflects the darkness of ignorance: even in the brightness of the noon's potential enlightenment (line 11's incandescence as impassioned endeavor) falters. The symbolic sunrise's hesitation (line 8) preponderates the speaker's poignant observation: "Today is yet to come / in Arkansas" (lines 17-18), and the alliteratively connotative allusion, "It writhes" (line 19), serves to complement the two similes.

The final stanza's comparing of the long-awaited enlightenment to something writhing evokes both the visual imagery of the first stanza's hanging bodies and, through embedded allusion, the first sin. The epanaleptic bracketing ("deep brooding" and awful / waves of brooding") of the past and the present and, optimistically, the future points to the liminality of the poem. The temporal threshold of the speaker's home, Arkansas, has "yet" to be crossed; the old hates and the metonymic ante-bellum lace have not been discarded (lines 14-16). The liminality of the potentiality of "deep brooding" (line 1) finds promised actuality in the image of the brooding's "writh[ing] in awful waves" (line 20).

The young writer might have something to say about the final stanza's "Old hates and / ante-bellum lace, are rent / but not discarded" as zeugma. The accusation of the pivotal line, "The past is brighter yet," might be recognized for the paradox that is informed by chiaroscuro (following the stanza's imagery) and synæsthesia (something temporal being treated as something visual).